

Humanity's Big Problem

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[The Peace Table](#)

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Abstract

This article argues that humanity's survival depends not on ideological consensus but on implementing the "Horticultural Model" of human development. Drawing on Abraham Maslow's idea of "big problems," the author contends that we already know how to create "good people": by sufficiently satisfying all seven essential human needs. Using the metaphor of tomato cultivation, the article demonstrates that healthy human development requires proper environmental conditions—nutrition, safety, connection, and freedom from toxic socialization—not moral instruction or genetic selection. The author dismisses debates over the definition of "goodness" as ideologically gridlocked, proposing instead a practical focus on systemic need-satisfaction. The article concludes by embedding a pointer to an extended theoretical dialogue exploring the cosmological and political implications of this framework, including the concept of consciousness as a "Fabric" seeking expression through healed physical vehicles.

Humanity's Big Problem

In a certain sense, only saints are [humankind].

All the rest are cripples. **Abraham Maslow**

In his book *The Farther Reaches of Human Nature*, [Abraham Maslow](https://spiritwiki.lightningpath.org/index.php/Abraham_Maslow)¹ discusses something he calls [Big Problems](https://spiritwiki.lightningpath.org/index.php/Big_Problems).² For Maslow, big problems refer to the fundamental, existential issues and challenges that humanity faces on a global scale. These are the profound questions about life, meaning, values, and survival that go beyond individual concerns and touch on universal human dilemmas, like the survival of the species. Maslow felt that if humanity was to advance towards self-actualization and transcendence, if humanity was to even survive as a viable species, it had to solve the big problems (Maslow, 1971).

In his book, Maslow identifies two pressing big problems, how to create the [Good Society](#) and how to create the [Good Person](#). Maslow felt the most pressing problem was how to make the good person. If we do not figure out a way to make that person, Maslow says, “we may all be wiped out” (Maslow, 1971, p. 18). This might have been hyperbole in the 1970s, but it is prophecy today. Fifty years on, our species is confronting a [polycrisis](#) that if not addressed may very well wipe us all out. Arguably, we need to start making good people right now or we are all doomed, bunker dwellers included.

Two questions arise at this point, “What is a good person?” and “How do you make one?” As Maslow himself recognized, the first question is philosophically, empirically, and emotionally challenging, so much so that I feel there is no point in even trying to address it, not because the answer is particularly challenging to come up with, but because the answer will bump up against several powerful, actively maintained ideological boundaries that prevent us from embracing some rather simple truths. Basically, no matter the logic or the evidence we present, we’re not going to get agreement.

1 https://spiritwiki.lightningpath.org/index.php/Abraham_Maslow

2 https://spiritwiki.lightningpath.org/index.php/Big_Problems

And that's fine.

We don't need agreement on what a good person is to advance because I feel we already know how to make a good person, and I don't think it is very complicated. In fact, I think that Maslow and the other humanists had that figured out over half a century ago. You create a good person by meeting the person's [Essential Needs](https://spiritwiki.lightningpath.org/index.php/Essential_Needs)³—all of them. That's it. That is all we have to do. Abraham Maslow referred to this as the [Horticultural Model](https://spiritwiki.lightningpath.org/index.php/Horticultural_Model)⁴ of human development (Maslow, 1996). This model treats human development as an organic unfolding of inherent potentials best supported by providing the right conditions (I would say [Right Environment](https://spiritwiki.lightningpath.org/index.php/Right_Environment)).⁵ If you provide the right conditions, you'll get a good human, end of line.

Maybe this sounds complicated, but it's not. Think of a tomato plant. If you want that plant to grow up healthy, whole, and the best it can, if you want it to be a robust producer of quality tomatoes, in other words if you want it to be a good tomato plant, you meet that plant's needs, for food, water, sun, and safety. It is common sense really. If you try and grow a tomato in a bush in depleted soil without enough water and in a location where animals are going to be tromping by and nibbling daily, that tomato plant is not going to get very far in life. It might not even survive. If you want a tomato to grow it needs to have lots of sun and it needs to be fed, watered, and protected.

To make a good tomato, meet its essential needs.

If you do that it will *naturally* and *inevitably* grow into a robust and productive plant. There will be variation, of course, and lots of it. But that's only bad if you are capitalist and want to standardize everything for efficiency and profit. If you are a chef or even a home cook, tomato variation is a great thing.

It is exactly the same with humans. Exactly the same common sense. If you want humans to grow up healthy, happy, strong, and whole, you meet all their essential needs. If you do that, you produce a good human. If you don't, you get something else.

It's not rocket science.

3 https://spiritwiki.lightningpath.org/index.php/Essential_Needs

4 https://spiritwiki.lightningpath.org/index.php/Horticultural_Model

5 https://spiritwiki.lightningpath.org/index.php/Right_Environment

The potential of a tomato plant is enhanced when you provide it with proper conditions. If you don't provide those conditions, it grows up stunted, or not at all.

This is also true of humans.

The potential of a human is enhanced when you provide it with the proper conditions. If you don't provide those conditions it grows up stunted, if at all.

This is not theory. This is established fact. Humans need the proper conditions. Consider this. Scientists have recently discovered that our diet at the age of two influences their IQ later in life, in exactly the way you would expect. If we give our kids a shitty diet filled with shitty ultraprocessed foods, we significantly lower their IQ ("Early Life Diets Quietly Shape IQ Years Later," 2026). And this is just one thing, one factor. If we start adding stress, neglect, abuse, and other elements of [Toxic Socialization](#)⁶ (Sosteric, 2025) to the process, like we have done for thousands of years, we're going to see complicated, accumulating, dramatic and systemic impacts that are going to eventually, obviously, and inevitably, destroy our species, thereby snuffing out humanity's great potential.

In other words, there's going to be no synthesis, dialectically speaking.

So...

...What are we going to do?

I guess that depends on the sorts of things *you* do. Since I'm a eupsychian theorist and since this article is really about human potential, I'm going to state it as plainly as possible so that everybody can understand. Maximizing individual and species potential requires the [Sufficient Satisfaction](#) of essential needs. I have said we have [Seven Essential Needs](#) (Sosteric, 2026), so that's what I'll say.

*Maximizing human potential requires the
sufficient satisfaction of all of its seven essential needs.*

We'll call this, after Maslow, the horticultural model of human development.

As for what *you* can do, do what you love to do and do it in way that helps you and others meet essential needs.

6 https://spiritwiki.lightningpath.org/index.php/Toxic_Socialization

If we all started doing that today

Then I think it is safe to say

Tomorrow would be a much better day.

We'll talk more next time.

If you want to be notified of new articles, follow us at [The Peace Table](#).⁷

** I don't know if anybody is interested, but I gave the final draft of this article to Claude for comment and we ended up in this deep cosmological, political, and psychological discussion. We called it the "[Dialogue on the Horticultural Model, Essential Needs, and the Fabric of Consciousness](#)." Click [this link](#) if you want to read it.*⁸

7 <https://medium.com/the-peace-table>

8 <https://www.kimi.com/share/19c90aaa-0972-8f04-8000-000080e021fa>